

WHIDBEY ISLAND HORSE COUNCIL
MEETING MINUTES
2/4/2026

The meeting was called to order at 6:35pm by coordinator Sally Garratt. It was conducted both via zoom and in person. Seven people were present including one new member who will be added to the email distribution list.

The Equine Economic Impact Survey committee met on 1/29. They are focusing on gathering names for an Equine-interested list and conducting a survey of horse owners/riders on the island. Currently, the committee has about 250 names and will continue to try to obtain more. The committee contacted the Kitsap county group that opposed the proposed regs that would have limited the ability to keep horses on private property and reviewed surveys done in PA, CA, and FL They will contact Betsy regarding an outreach effort and they hope to have a survey ready by April.

The Horse Research Directory was briefly discussed and we agreed that it needs expanding and more development. Sally will contact Thora to discuss what needs to be done.

Paula and Sally discussed the status of the County Comp Plan and mentioned several areas where we thought that input from horse owners should be included. They will draft proposed comments and submit the comments to the County by the February deadline.

Peggy discussed a proposed Equine Emergency Plan. She attended the "South Whidbey Prepares" meeting and included planning for large animals in their planning. She will follow up with other emergency planning on Whidbey to assure that we include large animals (horses) in any plans that are developed. Concerns include transportation, water, supplies and food needed in emergencies.

Other issues: We decided to pause any planning for a social event. We briefly discussed bills now pending in the state legislature. The bills of interest include the remote vet bill, the agro-tourist bill, and funding for DNR and State Parks. Bruce discussed the WITR members list and whether it should be included in the Equine Directory.

If you think of good survey questions, please send them to Jennifer or Leslie.

The Next meeting will be held on March 4, 2026 at 6:30 at the Race Road Fire Station.

